This time I didn't allow him to wriggle out so easily though he remained evasive. He indicated that there were some charges, he wasn't clear from who, and that there was corruption in the procurement of some furniture for ISRO's Mahendragiri ground testing facility, which came under the Liquid Propulsion Systems Group of which I was the deputy director.

Gowarikar wouldn't give me more details, but as I started speaking to more people involved in the purchase of furniture, the plot started becoming clearer to me.

As the chairman of the purchase committee for the Mahendragiri project, I had placed orders with Godrej for some furniture for the new facility. ISRO had a rate contract with Godrej, which meant the company had to provide us materials at a mutually agreed cost through the year. This purchase came under the rate contract.

Two months after the orders were placed, the local distributor, a man called Chittaranjan Das, came to me complaining that our stores department was not taking delivery of the furniture. Das said the consignment was taking up space in his godown, and he was losing money.

When I inquired with the store manager, he said since buildings were not yet ready at Mahendragiri, we could not take delivery.

'But that is being unfair to the distributor,' I said, ordering that the papers are cleared and delivery taken immediately.

Das later told me that the store manager approached him with the offer to take delivery of the furniture if paid a bribe. The distributor told the manager that he knew me personally and he would report this to me. Knowing my temper, the manager knew he would lose his job.

In his desperation, the store manager told P M Nair, the administrative head, that I was fast-tracking delivery of furniture because I had taken a bribe from the distributor.

Nair, who had a grudge against me from a previous incident when I exposed his mishandling of an ISRO drivers' strike, readily forwarded the complaint to Gowarikar, who in turn looked at me as his number one enemy Muthunayagam's deputy. Gowarikar transferred me.

Now that I was clear about the conspiracy, and my conscience, I went back to Dhawan.